
PAPERBOY

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 24, 2026

The ten-year Treasury yield closed at 5.11%, its highest since July 2007, after a flash PMI showed American business growing at its fastest rate in more than five years.

AI

Claude found an enzyme system nobody had characterised

WHAT HAPPENED

Anthropic [published](#) a research post saying Claude identified array-associated reverse transcriptases, a previously uncharacterised enzyme system in bacteriophages made of a reverse transcriptase, a partner gene and a long array of evenly spaced DNA repeats. The company's own headline calls the repeats CRISPR-like, not the system — worth keeping straight. It took roughly 950 agents, 210 million tokens and 21 hours of effort. The research group formed in the spring of 2026, works only at biosafety levels 1 and 2, and handles no human pathogens: “All of the lab work is performed by human scientists.” Dario Amodei [told TechCrunch](#) Claude found it “mostly, though not entirely,” and that Stanford researchers had previously found “a system that is in some ways similar to the one Claude found.”

WHAT IT MEANS

The enzyme is not the claim worth watching. The loop is: hypothesis generation run at agent scale against wet-lab validation the model does not control. Note that the Stanford caveat appears only in TechCrunch, the Anthropic post does not mention it, and none of this has been through peer review.

WATCH NEXT

A preprint naming the system, and whether an independent lab reproduces it.

The price war reaches speech

WHAT HAPPENED

A day after Anthropic and OpenAI cut frontier prices, Alibaba took the same move into audio, [launching Qwen Audio 3.1](#) as five models: speech recognition, a multi-speaker variant with timestamps and emotion detection, text-to-speech with cross-language voice transfer, a diffusion-paired model that generates voice and background audio together, and a real-time model that speaks and listens at once and can be interrupted mid-sentence. Cuts run roughly 70% on text-to-speech, 85% on the real-time model and up to 95% on recognition. Only percentages were published, no per-unit rates. Google shipped features rather than prices the same day — [Flash TTS models](#) that build voices from text descriptions, and [Gemini editing tools](#) inside YouTube's Creator Studio.

WHAT IT MEANS

Three of the four largest model vendors have cut prices inside 48 hours, and the deepest cut landed in the modality with the least differentiation. Google is the holdout on Gemini API pricing, though that is an absence of evidence rather than a decision anyone has announced.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Google matches on Gemini, and Anthropic's promised Sonnet 5.5 and Haiku 5.5.

ChatGPT's voice mode gets your inbox

WHAT HAPPENED

OpenAI extended ChatGPT Voice to read email, calendar and Slack and to act through plugins, running on the GPT-6 Astra, Sol and Luna models announced two days earlier. [TechCrunch](#) and [The Decoder](#) both carried it.

WHAT IT MEANS

The permission surface is the product here, not the voice. Read-and-act access to a work inbox from a conversational agent is the first consumer feature that needs an enterprise admin conversation before it ships.

WATCH NEXT

Admin controls, and whether this reaches Enterprise and Teams tenants.

AMD's 256-core Venice is aimed at Nvidia, not just Intel

WHAT HAPPENED

AMD [detailed Venice](#), its biggest server-CPU change since Rome in 2019. The density part reaches 256 Zen 6 cores across eight 32-core chiplets, boosting to 4.1GHz; a frequency-optimised 96-core part runs to 5GHz; the GPU-host “Verano” variant tops out at 72 cores on LPDDR5x. The SP7 platform carries 16 channels of DDR5 at 8,000 MT/s (12,800 with MRDIMMs), 128 lanes of PCIe 6.0, CXL 3.1 and 1.6TB/s of memory bandwidth. Shared L3 quadruples to 128MB per chiplet, 1,024MB per socket. SP7 ships in 2026, enterprise SP8 and HPC parts in 2027, Verano in the second half of 2027.

WHAT IT MEANS

AMD's own whitepaper claims the 96-core part beats Nvidia's Vera CPU by between 1% and 12% across four SPEC 2026 benchmarks, and 2.24x throughput for 256-core Venice against 88-core Vera. These are vendor benchmarks and easy to cherry-pick, but the target is clear: the host-CPU slot in AI racks, not the Xeon fight. Intel's Diamond Rapids matches the headline specs with no enterprise SKUs, which hands AMD volume through much of 2027.

WATCH NEXT

Independent SPEC submissions, and whether Nvidia answers on Vera.

Chips led the tape down, and it was a rates move

WHAT HAPPENED

The [SOX semiconductor index closed at 12,534.27](#) on Wednesday, down 155.55 or 1.23%, giving back part of a two-session run that had added more than 6%. The fall roughly matched the [Nasdaq Composite's 1.13%](#), which came off Tuesday's record close. No chip-specific news broke: TrendForce published nothing dated the 23rd or 24th, and Micron, TSMC, Intel, SK hynix and Nvidia were all quiet. What did move was the front end of the Treasury curve, where the two-year [rose 14 basis points in a session](#).

WHAT IT MEANS

Two sessions ago memory was leading the tape on DDR4 tightness and SOX put on 4.29% then 2.06%. This was the discount rate, not demand: a sector priced on earnings a long way out reprices hardest when the belly of the curve moves 15 basis points in a day.

WATCH NEXT

Micron's fiscal Q1 on 30 September — memory pricing and the unasked-about YMTC injunctions in one call. Intel's reported 5 October price rise; TSMC around the 10th.

US flash PMI at a 62-month high, with input costs at a four-year one

WHAT HAPPENED

S&P Global's [flash US composite output index](#) jumped to 58.4 in September from 56.0, the strongest reading in 62 months. Manufacturing rose to 57.0 from 53.9, a 52-month high; services business activity to 58.7 from 56.5. Employment grew at its fastest rate since June 2022, new orders at the fastest since March 2022 in services. Input costs rose at the steepest rate in four years — the highest since October 2022 — which S&P puts down to fuel, transport and wages. Prices charged went the other way, accelerating but staying below the rates seen between March and July as competition bit. Collection ran 10–22 September.

WHAT IT MEANS

Chris Williamson: “US business continues to boom, with output growing at the fastest rate for over five years in September.” And the sting, on rising backlogs: they indicate “that companies are developing more pricing power, and hence is a worry for the inflation outlook.” A Fed that hiked to 3.75–4.00% last week just got evidence it was right rather than early.

WATCH NEXT

August PCE on 26 September; September CPI around 13 October.

The ten-year closed at 5.11%, its highest since July 2007

WHAT HAPPENED

Treasury par yields rose 14 to 16 basis points across the two- to ten-year belly on Wednesday. The two-year [went to 4.85%](#) from 4.71%, the ten-year to 5.11% from 4.96%, the twenty-year to 5.45% and the thirty-year to 5.40%. The ten-year has not been above 5.11% since late July 2007. Equities fell with bonds: the [S&P 500 lost 0.75% to 7,706.03](#), the Nasdaq Composite 1.13% to 26,936.04 from Tuesday's record, the Dow 0.68% to 51,511.59, and the Russell 2000 1.77%.

WHAT IT MEANS

Stocks and bonds falling together is the inflation trade, not the growth trade. The market read a 62-month-high PMI carrying four-year-high input costs as a Fed with more work to do, and repriced the front end hardest — which is the opposite of the steepening-at-the-front story of two days ago.

WATCH NEXT

PCE on the 26th, and the first Fed speaker willing to say December is live.

Brent back above \$100 as Iran's price for Hormuz sits unanswered

WHAT HAPPENED

Crude reversed six straight daily losses with a gain of about 4% on Wednesday. Brent traded at [\\$102.03, up 2.78%](#) intraday, roughly 50% above the \$67.85 of a year earlier; by Thursday morning oilprice.com's live quote had Brent at \$105.40 and WTI at \$93.85 — an intraday tick, not a settle. Iran's three conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz — lifting the naval blockade on its ports, ending sanctions, unfreezing assets — [remain unanswered](#) by Washington. Saudi Arabia's restarted East-West pipeline had briefly pushed Brent under \$100 earlier in the week.

WHAT IT MEANS

This is the input cost inside the PMI. Oil is now the transmission mechanism between the war and the Fed, which makes the Iran track a rates story whether anyone frames it that way or not.

WATCH NEXT

The UN Iran panel of experts on 27 September, and whether a second round of indirect talks gets scheduled.

STARTUPS

Bessemer raises \$5.75bn and puts 70% of it at growth stage

WHAT HAPPENED

Bessemer Venture Partners [closed \\$5.75 billion](#) across two funds: \$1.75bn for seed and early stage, \$4bn for growth. The mandate spans compute, infrastructure, foundation models, developer tools and agentic applications. The firm says it has backed more than 260 AI-native companies since 2022 and deployed \$3 billion into AI startups, naming Anthropic, Cognition, Legora, Perplexity, Ramp, Shopify and Waymo. Partner Byron Deeter: “AI-native companies are scaling faster than any category of technology we've backed before.” He told Bloomberg that companies staying private longer is “a permanent structural shift” — a quote reaching us second-hand through TechCrunch.

WHAT IT MEANS

The split is the signal. A firm built on early-stage enterprise SaaS now needs four dollars of late-stage capital for every \$1.75 of early, because the companies it seeded in 2023 are raising rounds the size of small IPOs and have no reason to list.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the growth fund's first cheques go into companies Bessemer already owns.

Ema raises \$77m at more than four times its last valuation, undisclosed

WHAT HAPPENED

Ema, which sells “AI employee” agents that run HR, IT and finance workflows inside existing enterprise apps, [raised a \\$77 million Series B](#) led by Creaegis, with Accel, S32 and Prosus all adding to existing positions. Total raised is \$140 million. The company says revenue grew 50x over 24 months and that the round “more than quadruples” its prior valuation, without naming a figure. Chief executive Surojit Chatterjee: “Enterprises do not need more software. They need work to get done.” [TechCrunch](#) reads it as AI eating enterprise software and services budgets at once. Enveda separately announced [\\$311 million](#) for nature-derived AI drug discovery; that one is TechCrunch-only so far.

WHAT IT MEANS

A disclosed multiple with an undisclosed valuation is the tell of a market where the multiple is the marketing. 50x on a base that was tiny 24 months ago is a real number and a small one, and a 4x step-up on an unnamed base cannot be checked by anybody.

WATCH NEXT

Whether any agentic-enterprise company publishes net revenue retention rather than a growth multiple, and whether Enveda's round is confirmed by a company release.

Bessent extends the Busan tariff truce to 10 January — on television

WHAT HAPPENED

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on Fox News' "Special Report" on Wednesday that the US-China tariff truce, due to expire 10 November, will now run to 10 January. His words, [as carried](#): "We will extend what we call the 'Busan Agreement' — the economic détente between the two countries that was scheduled to end on Nov. 10 — that is going to be extended until Jan. 10," to "give us more time to see what we can do on the economic front." He had met Vice Premier He Lifeng in Washington earlier that day, hours before Xi Jinping landed. There is no Treasury or White House release, no joint statement, and nothing from Beijing's foreign ministry.

WHAT IT MEANS

A two-month extension of the tariff arrangement announced by one official on a cable programme, with the Chinese side silent. Either it is a summit deliverable being pre-trailed, or it is a US negotiating position being stated as a fact. Multiple outlets carry it; no government has put it in writing.

WATCH NEXT

A Treasury or USTR release, and whether Thursday's readouts from either side mention 10 January.

Colmenero confirmed 50-47 on a party-line vote

WHAT HAPPENED

The Senate [confirmed Angela Veronica Colmenero](#) of Texas to the US District Court for the Southern District of Texas at 2.16pm Wednesday, 50 yeas to 47 nays with three not voting. It was roll call 241 and the [only vote of the day](#). All 50 yeas were Republican, all 47 nays Democratic, and all three absences Republican. Cloture had cleared 52-43 the day before. Nothing new appeared on [whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions](https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions) either: the 18 September H-1B executive order is still the most recent presidential action.

WHAT IT MEANS

A three-vote margin with three of your own members absent is the thinnest arithmetic that still works — judges confirmed on attendance rather than persuasion, which holds until a flight is delayed.

WATCH NEXT

The next tranche of district nominees on the executive calendar.

Missouri's congressional map reaches the Supreme Court a third time

WHAT HAPPENED

Missouri [filed on Wednesday](#) asking the justices to leave in place Monday's Eighth Circuit decision, which directs the state to use its 2025 congressional map — drawn to add a Republican House seat — in November. A federal judge had barred the map on 10 September. The case is *People Not Politicians v. Onder*, 26A388, and the primary is already under way. Missouri's filing warns that “Voter and candidate confusion will persist, Missouri will endure a fifth court-ordered change to its map in September, hundreds of thousands of voters in the Primary Election will be disenfranchised.”

WHAT IT MEANS

Opponents have been to this Court twice already on this map. The live question is no longer whether the map is lawful but whether an election can be administered on one that has changed five times inside a month — and the state is now making the chaos its own argument for winning.

WATCH NEXT

An order from the Court. It has moved in days, not weeks, on election-calendar applications.

WORLD POLITICS

Xi lands in Washington; the substance is still to come

WHAT HAPPENED

Xi Jinping arrived at Joint Base Andrews on Wednesday and Trump met him planeside — a [100-foot red carpet](#), a [21-person honour guard](#), a [B-1 flyover](#). Trump afterwards: “I think they appreciate it, tremendous people.” The South Lawn arrival ceremony, the bilateral and a black-tie dinner whose guest list [includes Jensen Huang and Elon Musk](#) were all scheduled for Thursday, after this brief closed. Nothing substantive has been agreed: no joint statement, no tariff change, no rare-earths or export-control outcome. AI, Iran and Taiwan are on the agenda.

WHAT IT MEANS

The choreography is doing the work while the substance isn't settled. A planeside greeting is a protocol concession that costs nothing and reads as warmth — what you offer when nothing is ready to sign.

WATCH NEXT

Thursday's readouts, and whether Beijing confirms 10 January in its own words.

Zelensky at the UN: “patient zero must be stopped”

WHAT HAPPENED

Zelensky [told the General Debate](#) on Wednesday that Russia's war is a contagion the world failed to contain, and aimed his ask at Russia's revenue rather than at weapons: “A war that was not prevented in time, was not stopped in time, and for which Russia was not punished in time, keeps spreading and spreads evil with it.” And: “When someone gives Russia more money through trade, they give this war more time.” He closed, “Patient zero must be stopped. Limit his room to act, limit his money, limit his war.” He put Russian losses at nearly 249,000 killed or seriously wounded in the first eight months of 2026 — his own figure, not independently confirmed. Overnight into Thursday, ballistic missiles [hit Kyiv](#), killing two and injuring at least eight across three districts; Ukraine's air defence claimed four Zircons, three ballistic missiles and 219 drones downed, which is its own account of its own operations.

WHAT IT MEANS

A sanctions speech, addressed to the states still buying Russian energy rather than those arming Ukraine. Its other number is the more striking one: the air force says jet-powered drone use went from 350 in June to 2,850 in August.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Macron's energy-strike moratorium finds takers, and whether the tempo holds past UNGA week.

Pezeshkian answers Trump, and a US envoy walks out

WHAT HAPPENED

Iran's president [addressed the Assembly](#) a day after Trump threatened to annihilate the Islamic Republic, and a US envoy walked out during the speech. Pezeshkian turned the terrorism charge around — “Those who are terrorists...describe us using that word” — and on the nuclear file said: “The nuclear weapon is in Israel, but the inspectors are in Iran. Israel kills, but Iran is subject to sanctions.” He said Iranians had been “in the streets every night” for seven months in support of their country, and put Gaza's civilian dead at 80,000; both are his own contested assertions. Separately he called Trump's remarks “[a sign of a bullying mentality](#)”, adding that “the Iranian people will not bow to pressure.”

WHAT IT MEANS

The door is not shut. Tehran's price for reopening Hormuz was restated in New York rather than withdrawn, which makes it a negotiating list. Two leaders traded maximal rhetoric in the same hall while their envoys kept talking through mediators.

WATCH NEXT

The UN Iran panel of experts on 27 September; Netanyahu at the podium on the 24th.

SOURCES

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[US Treasury — daily par yield curve, 2026](#)

[Nasdaq — PHLX Semiconductor Index \(SOX\)](#)

[Investing.com — S&P 500 historical data](#)

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[Anthropic — Claude discovers a novel enzyme system](#)

[TechCrunch — Anthropic's biology lab](#)

[The Decoder — Alibaba's Qwen Audio 3.1](#)

[The Decoder — Google's Flash TTS models](#)

[TechCrunch — YouTube Studio AI features](#)

[TechCrunch — ChatGPT voice agentic features](#)

[The Register — AMD's 256-core Venice](#)

[TechCrunch — Bessemer's \\$5.75bn](#)

[Ema — \\$77m Series B \(company release\)](#)

[TechCrunch — Ema raises \\$77m](#)

[TechCrunch — Enveda's \\$311m](#)

[US Senate — roll call vote 241 \(Colmenero\)](#)

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[White House — presidential actions](#)

[SCOTUSblog — Missouri's redistricting map](#)

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[Jerusalem Post — truce extended through 10 January](#)

[UN News — Zelensky's General Debate address](#)

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